

Social Media Crisis Response Plan

Template & Escalation Tree

The worst time to decide who responds is during the crisis. Fill this template out now, store it where the team can reach it, and rehearse it once.

What's inside

- Three-tier severity classification
- Pre-approved holding statements
- Escalation contact tree
- Do-not-engage criteria
- Post-incident review format

Severity Tiers

- 01 Tier 1: isolated complaint — respond publicly, resolve privately
- 02 Tier 2: pattern of complaints — pause scheduled posts, brief leadership
- 03 Tier 3: viral or legal exposure — full escalation, single spokesperson
- 04 Define who classifies severity and how fast

First 60 Minutes

- 01 Acknowledge publicly before you have full answers
- 02 Pause all scheduled and automated content immediately
- 03 Move detail to a private channel; keep the public reply short
- 04 Log everything with timestamps and screenshots

Do Not Engage When

- 01 The account is an obvious troll seeking a reaction
- 02 The matter is under active legal or HR process
- 03 Responding would amplify a low-visibility post
- 04 You cannot yet confirm the facts

After Action

- 01 Document the timeline while memories are fresh
- 02 Identify the trigger and whether it was preventable
- 03 Update the plan with what actually happened
- 04 Share learnings across marketing, support, and product

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